



UNIVERSITY OF AMSTERDAM
Amsterdam Business School

Picture source: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Guernica_\(Picasso\)#/media/File:PicassoGuernica.jpg](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Guernica_(Picasso)#/media/File:PicassoGuernica.jpg)

MScBA: Ethics and the Future of Business

SESSION 3: STRATEGIES & STAKEHOLDERS

Arno Kourula – 7 September 2026



Recap of last week

1. Descriptive theories in ethics

- Ethical decision-making process
- Individual and situational factors

2. Intuition vs. rationality

- Cognitive biases

3. Ethics in action

- Business ethics tools
- Responsible and ethical AI



Photo by Geran de Klerk on Unsplash

Agenda for today

1. Changing behavior
2. Corporate responsibility and sustainability
 - Drivers of corporate responsibility
 - Corporate responsibility and digital economy
3. Stakeholder thinking
4. Recap

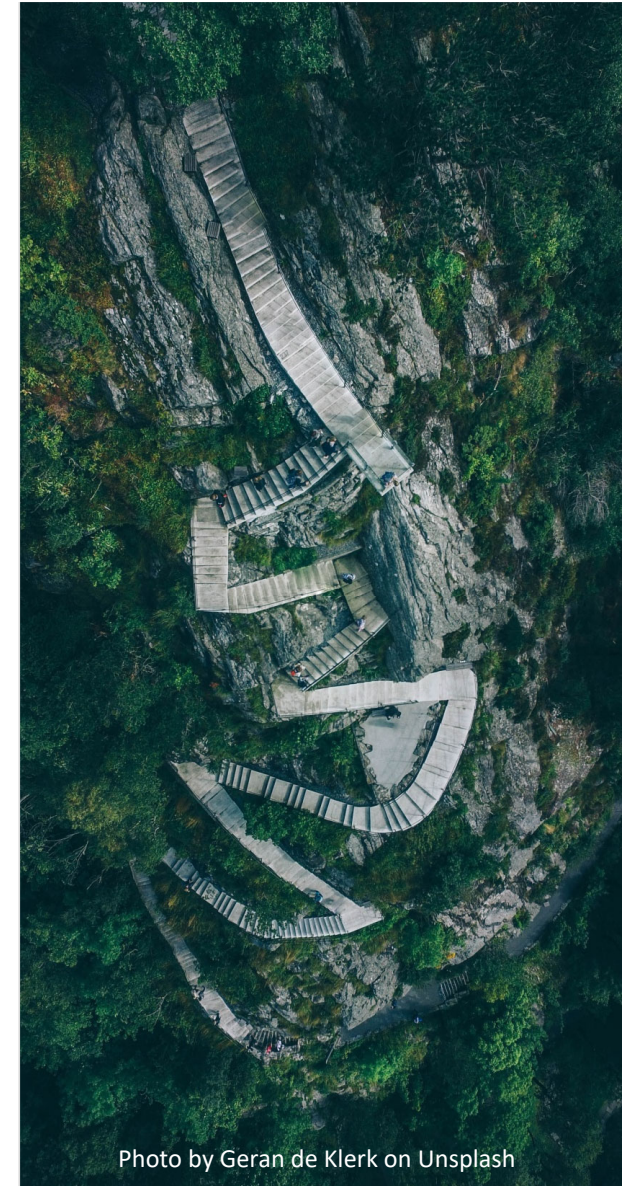
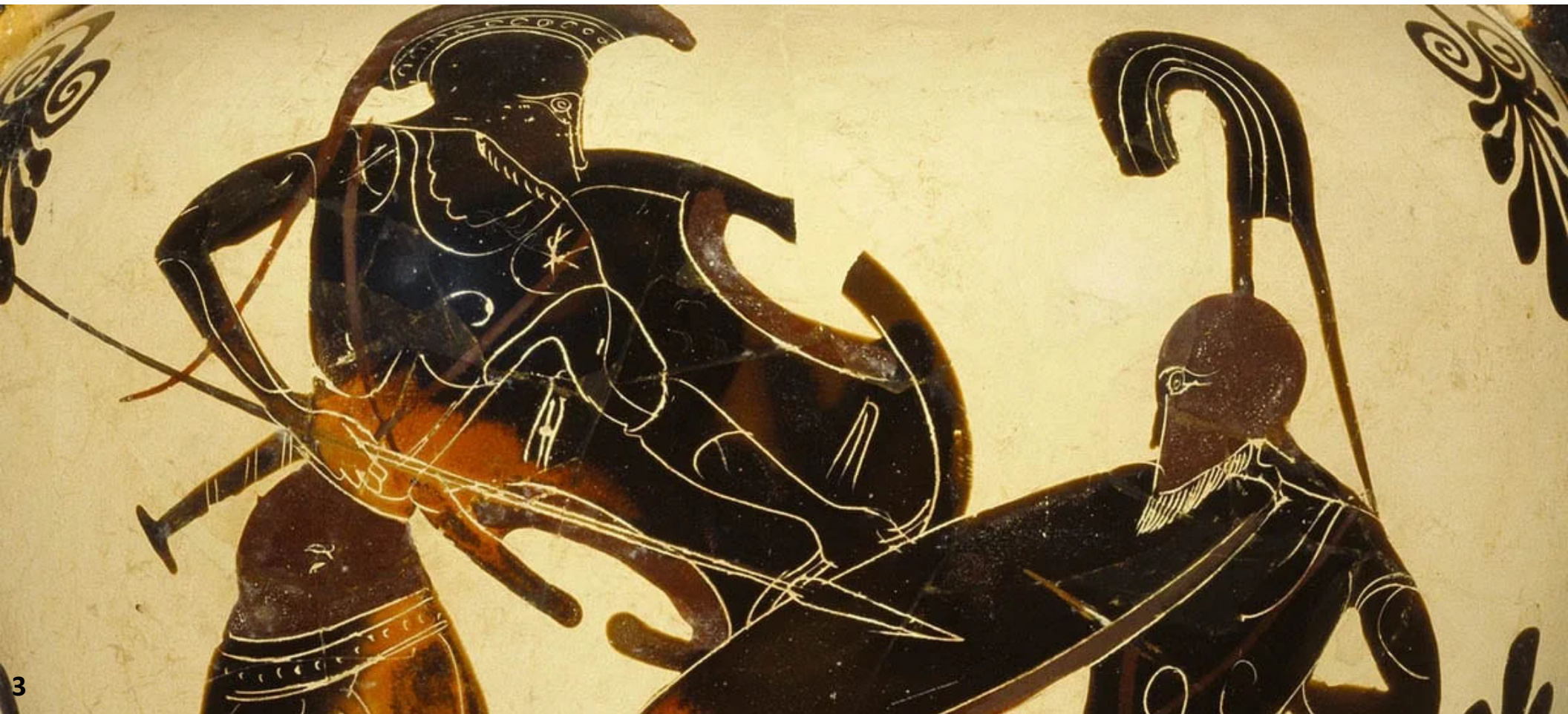


Photo by Geran de Klerk on Unsplash



1. Changing behavior

Picture source: www.thecollector.com/trojan-war-heroes/





Evolutionary bases of behavior

(Griskevicius et al 2012)

Goals:

- *Proximate*: Culture, incentives, preferences, learning, utility, pleasure, values, personality, etc.
- *Ultimate*: Evolutionary bases.

Mismatches between current and ancestral:

1. Propensity of self-interest
2. Motivation for relative rather than absolute status
3. Proclivity to unconsciously copy others
4. Predisposition to be short-sighted
5. Proneness to disregard impalpable concerns

Evolutionary: 1. Self-interest?

(Griskevicius et al 2012)

Tendency:

- *People prioritize self-interest over group behavior.*

Principles:

1. Kin selection
2. Reciprocal altruism
3. Indirect reciprocity

Solutions?

1. Highlight individual benefits
2. Create small dense networks
3. Threaten reputation
4. Donate first, then ask to reciprocate.



Source: www.givingcompass.org/article/why-not-volunteer-three-benefits-of-corporate-volunteering/

Evolutionary: 2. Relative status?

(Griskevicius et al 2012)

Tendency:

- *People are more motivated by relative status than absolute status.*

Principles:

1. Costly signaling
2. Competitive altruism

Solutions?

1. Pro-social competition and rankings
2. Easily identifiable self-sacrificing behavior



Source: imaginelifestyles.com

Corporate Knights
SINCE 2002

2025 Global 100 sustainable
companies list

Source: www.corporateknights.com/



Source: <https://rankings.newsweek.com/worlds-greenest-companies-2025>

Evolutionary: 3. Social imitation?

(Griskevicius et al 2012)

Tendency:

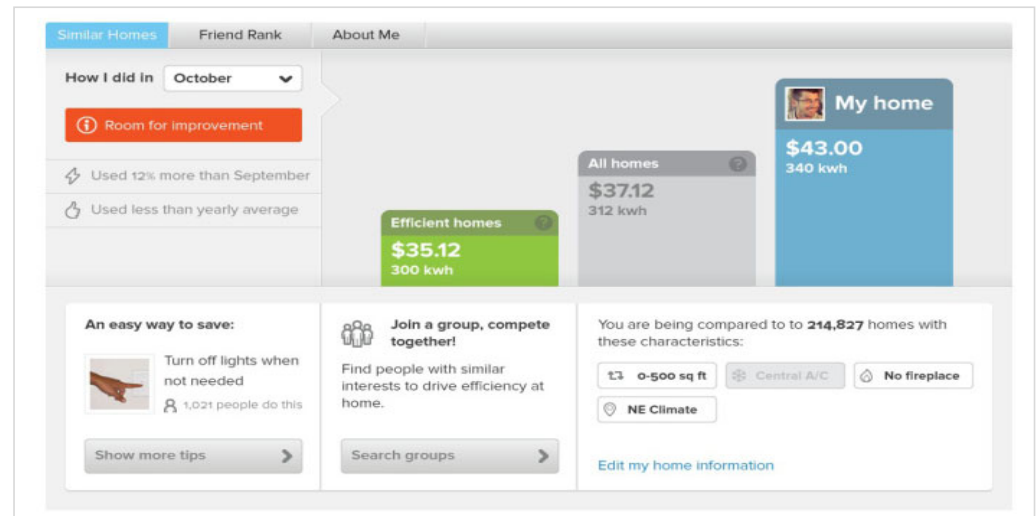
- *People copy unconsciously what others are doing.*

Principles:

1. Mimicry
2. Cultural evolution
3. Social norms

Solutions?

1. Depict high prevalence of desired behavior
2. Use social approval



Source: <https://gigaom.com/>

Evolutionary: 4. Future discounting?

(Griskevicius et al 2012)

Tendency:

- *People value the present more than the future.*

Principles:

1. Life history theory
2. Sexual selection
3. Parental investment

Solutions?

1. Emphasize present consequences
2. Highlight stability
3. Attractiveness of social and sustainable behavior



Source: www.un.org/en/messengers-peace/leonardo-dicaprio



Source: www.cartrade.com/blog/2016/celebrity-owned-cars/leonardo-dicaprio-owns-a-toyota-prius-1670.html

Evolutionary: 5. Impalpable concerns?

(Griskevicius et al 2012)

Tendency:

- *People disregard problems they cannot see or feel.*

Principles:

1. Sensory mechanisms
2. Environmental mismatch
3. Biophilia

Solutions?

1. Locality of environmental problems
2. Create links between behavior and consequences



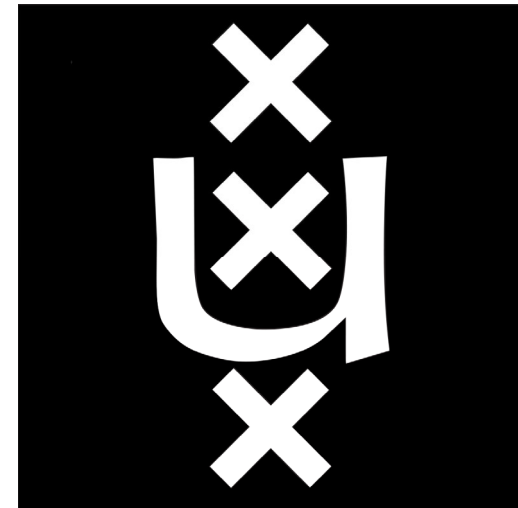
Source: <https://www.ams-institute.org/urban-challenges/resilient-cities/>



Discussion

How can we use these **evolutionary principles** to make the University of Amsterdam **more sustainable**?

Think of practical examples...



Source: www.uva.nl

2. Corporate responsibility and sustainability

Picture source: https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/f/fd/David_-_Napoleon_crossing_the_Alps_-_Malmaison2.jpg





A Changing Context for Business, Nature, and Society

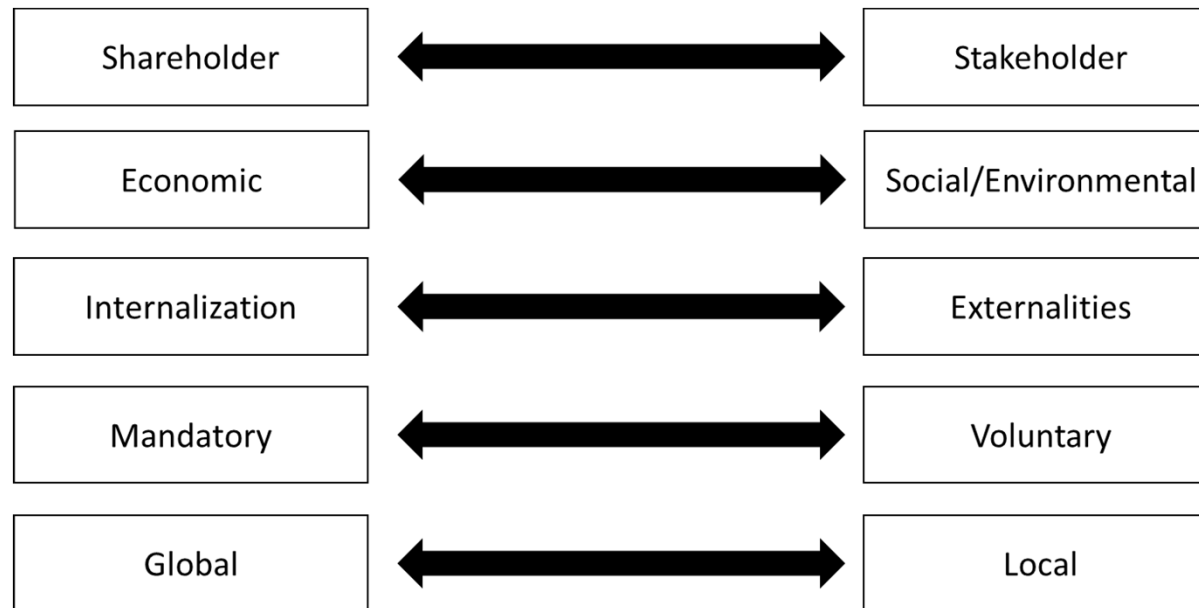


Rasche et al. 2023. *Corporate sustainability*. Cambridge University Press.

Corporate (social) responsibility and related tensions

Corporate Social Responsibility “refers to the integration of an enterprise's social, environmental, ethical and philanthropic responsibilities towards society into its operations, processes and core business strategy in cooperation with relevant stakeholders in a context-specific way”.

Rasche et al. 2023



Rasche et al. 2023. *Corporate sustainability*. Cambridge University Press.

Sustainable development and corporate sustainability

Meeting “the needs of the present, without compromising the ability of **future generations** to meet their needs”.

World Commission on Environment and Development. 1987. Our Common Future, a.k.a. Brundtland report

“Corporate sustainability focuses on **managing and balancing** an enterprise’s **embeddedness** in interrelated ecological, social and economic systems so that **positive impact** is created in the form of long-term ecological balance, societal welfare and stakeholder value”.

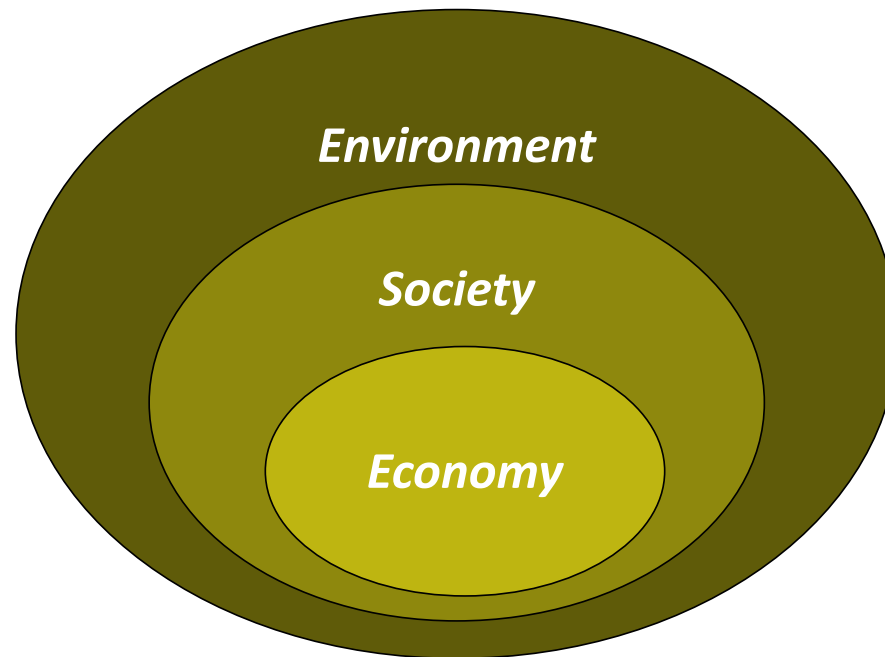
Rasche et al. 2023.



Gro Harlem Brundtland

Sources: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gro_Harlem_Brundtland#/media/File:Gro_Harlem_Brundtland_\(cropped\).jpg](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gro_Harlem_Brundtland#/media/File:Gro_Harlem_Brundtland_(cropped).jpg) / / Rasche et al. 2023. *Corporate sustainability*. Cambridge University Press.

Corporate sustainability



Marcus, A. A., & Fremeth, A. R. 2009. Green management matters regardless. *Academy of Management Perspectives*, 23(3): 17-26. / Rasche et al. 2023. *Corporate sustainability*. Cambridge University Press.

Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) Issues

Environmental	Social	Governance	Technology
• Carbon emissions • Waste & recycling • Water management • Biodiversity • Land use • Deforestation • Raw material sourcing	• Health and safety • Community relations • Diversity and inclusion • Employee pay • Union relations • Poverty • Training and education	• Corruption • Executive Pay • Board diversity • Stakeholder rights • CEO duality • Voting procedures • Lobbying	• Cybersecurity • Fake news • Dark web • Data mining • Robotic processing • Bioengineering • Surveillance

The EU Green Deal – Four Pillars With Special Relevance for Corporate Sustainability as a Whole (not for exam) (Rasche, 2025)

ESG Reporting

- Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive (CSRD)
- European Sustainability Reporting Standards (ESRS)
- EU Environmental Taxonomy

Value Chains

- Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive (CSDDD)
- EU Forced Labour Regulation
- EU Deforestation Regulation (EUDR)
- EU Ecodesign Regulation

Green Claims

- Empowering Consumers for the Green Transition Directive
- Green Claims Directive (GCD)

ESG Investing

- Sustainable Finance Disclosure Regulation (SFDR)
- ESG Ratings Regulation

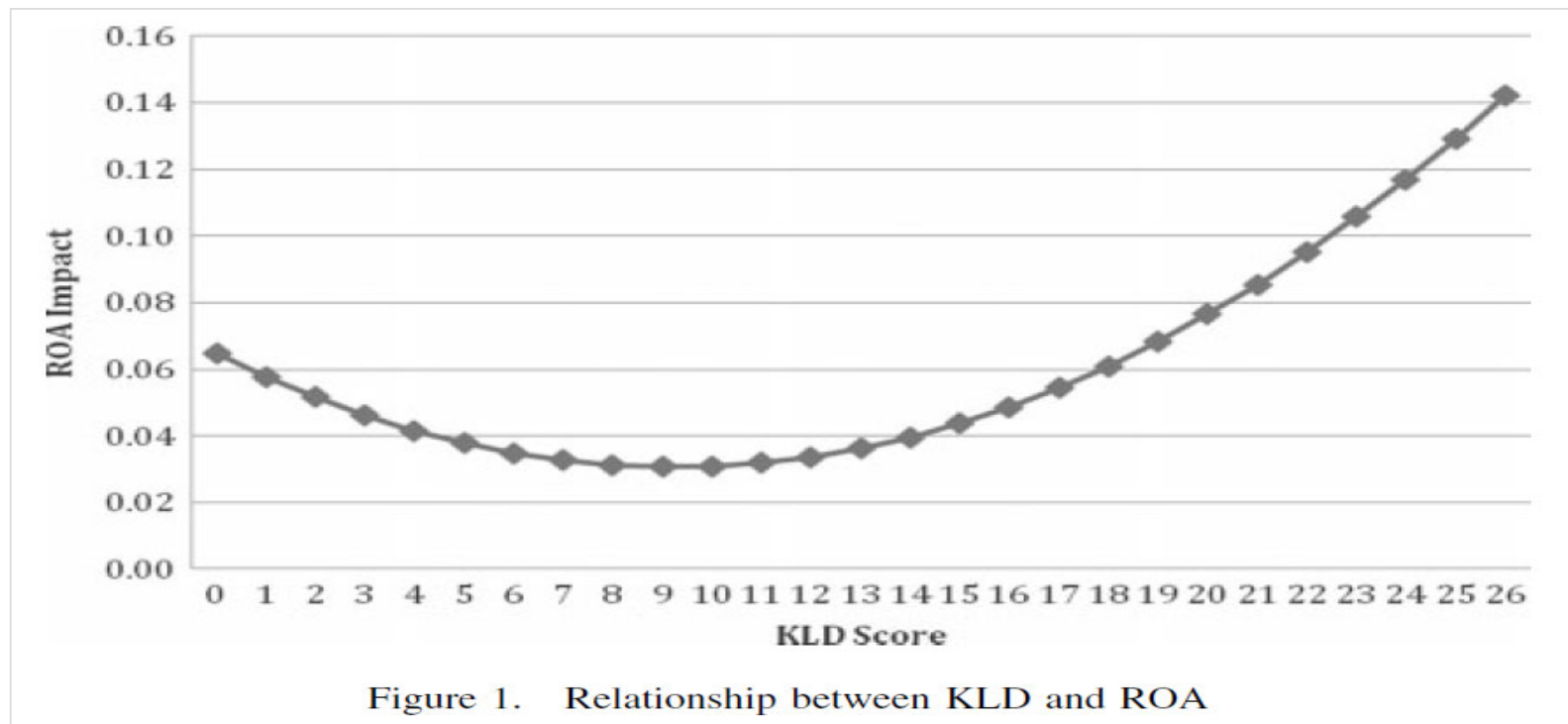
How corporate sustainability influences firm value?

Growth	New Markets & Geographies
	New Customers & Market Share
	Product & Service Innovation
Return on Capital	Operational Efficiency
	Human Capital Management
	Reputation Pricing Power
Risk Management	Operational and Regulatory Risk
	Reputational Risk
	Supply Chain Risk

Sources: UN Global Compact and the Principles for Responsible Investment (2013) / Rasche et al. 2023. *Corporate sustainability*. Cambridge University Press.

When does it pay to be green/responsible?

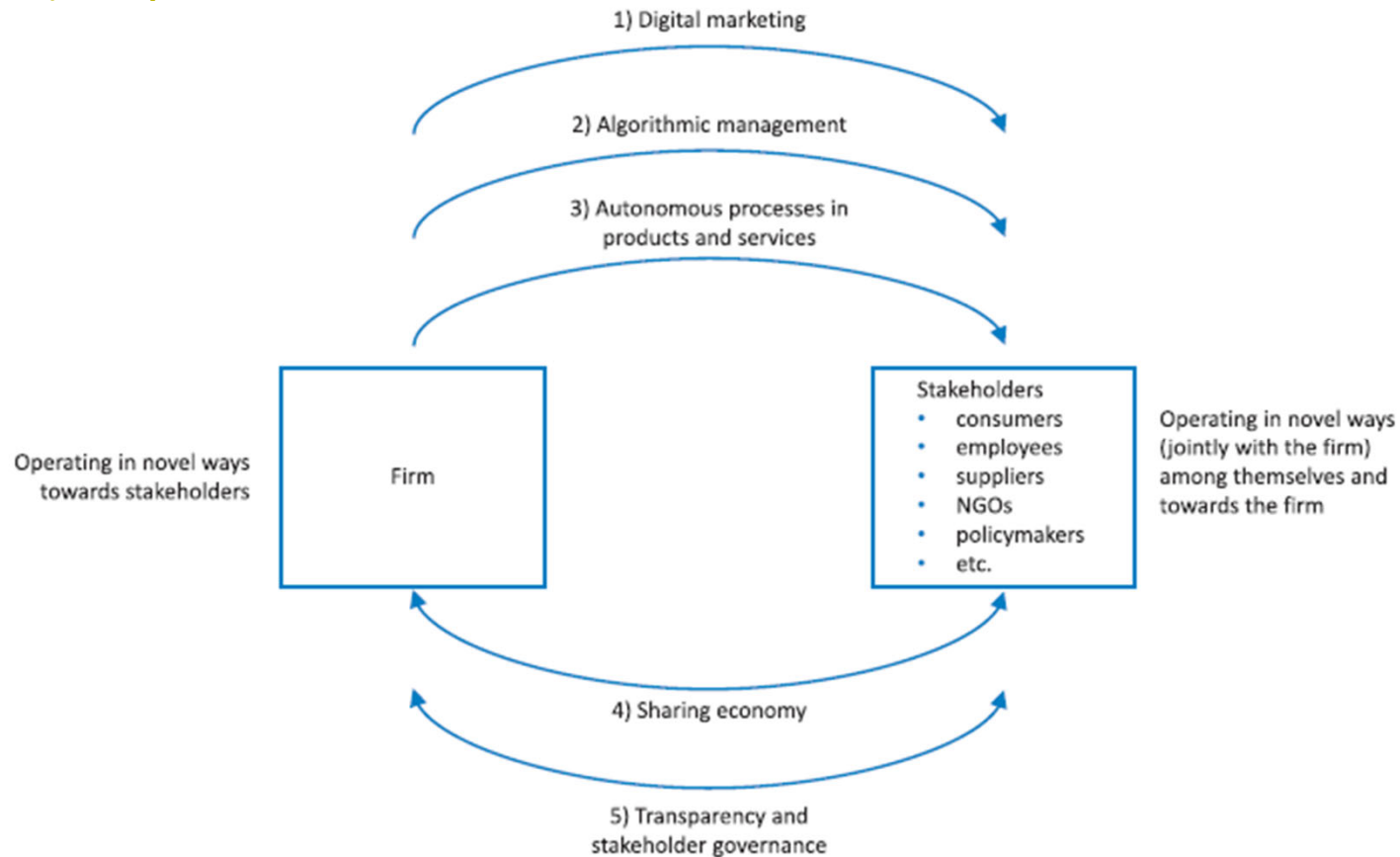
(Barnett & Salomon, 2012)



Source: Barnett, M. L., & Salomon, R. M. 2012. Does it pay to be really good? Addressing the shape of the relationship between social and financial performance. Strategic Management Journal, 33: 1304-1320.

Corporate Responsibility & Digital Economy

(Lankoski & Smith, 2025)



Lankoski, L., & Smith, C. 2025. Corporate responsibility meets the digital economy, *California Management Review*, online first.

Corporate Responsibility & Digital Economy

(Lankoski & Smith, 2025)

	Examples of Associated Ethical Issues	
	Positive	Negative
Digital marketing (Personalized targeting of messages, dynamic and personalized pricing)	Better understanding of consumer needs, lower prices for some consumers	Consumer privacy and autonomy, higher or unfair pricing for some consumers
Algorithmic management (Monitoring of employee or supplier performance, work scheduling, use of AI in hiring)	Consistency in employee treatment	Reduced employee freedom, privacy, respect; "Taylorism on steroids;" bias
Autonomous processes in products and services [Algorithms (e.g., credit decisions), robots (e.g., drones, self-operating vehicles)]	Machines acting without human weaknesses (such as cognitive limits, lack of self-control)	Machines different from humans (morals), similar to humans (bias), replacing humans (job loss, singularity), lack of explainability
Sharing economy [Uber, Lyft (transportation), Airbnb (accommodation), Mechanical Turk (tasks)]	Saving resources through sharing	Accountability, assignment of responsibility, bias in ratings, working conditions
Transparency and stakeholder governance (Availability and communication of information, dialogue and engagement)	(Super)transparency, traceability, accountability	Spreading false information, pressuring companies to move or act in undesirable directions

Lankoski, L., & Smith, C. 2025. Corporate responsibility meets the digital economy, *California Management Review*, online first.

Corporate Responsibility & Digital Economy

(Lankoski & Smith, 2025)

Questions Defining CR Landscape	Changes Brought to CR by Digitalization	Implications for Managers
Responsible for what?	Existing CR issues manifest in novel ways	Break silos between CR management and digitalization management
	Existing CR issues alleviated or solved	Screen for opportunities for reducing footprints and increasing handprints, e.g., through AI
	Existing CR issues intensified	Revisit double materiality assessments
	New CR issues arising ^a	Interpret developments and anticipate their impacts
Responsible toward whom?	Salience of existing stakeholder groups changed	Changed prioritization of stakeholder engagement and management attention
	New stakeholder groups emerging ^a	Be attuned to emergence of new stakeholders and concomitant responsibilities
Who is responsible?	Responsibility boundaries blurred between firms and individuals and among firms ^a	Ensure clear responsibility boundaries in negotiations and contracts
	Novel questions raised on where responsibility resides between humans and machines ^a	Follow societal discussions and regulatory developments; do not hide behind AI

Lankoski, L., & Smith, C. 2025. Corporate responsibility meets the digital economy, *California Management Review*, online first.



3. Stakeholder thinking

Picture source:

https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/7/7d/The_French_defeated_before_Calais_by_Edward_III.jpg



Stakeholders and stakeholder theory

Stakeholder theory aims to explain the **nature of relationships** between organisations and those persons **with a 'stake'** in the **operations and outcomes of business activity**.

Stakeholder: *"any group or individual that can affect or is affected by the achievement of an organization's objectives"* (Freeman, 1984).

Stakeholder theory has three focus areas (Donaldson & Preston, 1995):

- Descriptive – outline critical relationships
- Instrumental – identify effective practices
- Normative – critique the role and purpose of the firm

"In the long run, those who do not use power in a manner which society considers responsible will tend to lose it"
(Davis & Blomstrom, 1971)

Sources: Freeman, R.E. (1984). Strategic Management: a stakeholder approach. Boston: Pitman. / Donaldson, T. & Preston, L.E. 1995. The Stakeholder Theory of the Corporation: Concepts, Evidence, and Implications. Academy of Management Review, 20(1). / Davis, K., & Blomstrom, R. L. 1971. Business, society, and environment: Social power and social response (2nd Ed). New York: McGraw-Hill.

Case Fairphone

Basics:

- Small electronics manufacturer / social enterprise.
- Founded in 2013 in Amsterdam.
- Aiming to make mobile phones sustainable (conflict minerals, fair labor conditions, circularity through modularity and repair).
- Challenger to Samsung, Apple, ...

Examples of strategies:

1. Focus on sustainable impact
2. Maximize market share
3. Sell off company to competitor



Stakeholder engagement (BSR 2019)



DO

Link engagement strategy to business strategy.

Focus Internally before externally (gain buy-in, find champions).

Learn from past experience, both successes and failures.



DON'T

Decide on stakeholders before deciding on your objectives.

Jump directly to choosing an engagement format.

Ignore Internal concerns.

Stakeholder mapping process (BSR 2019)

Four Phases of Stakeholder Mapping



Stakeholder identification (BSR 2019)

Brainstorm a list of stakeholders without screening. Examples:

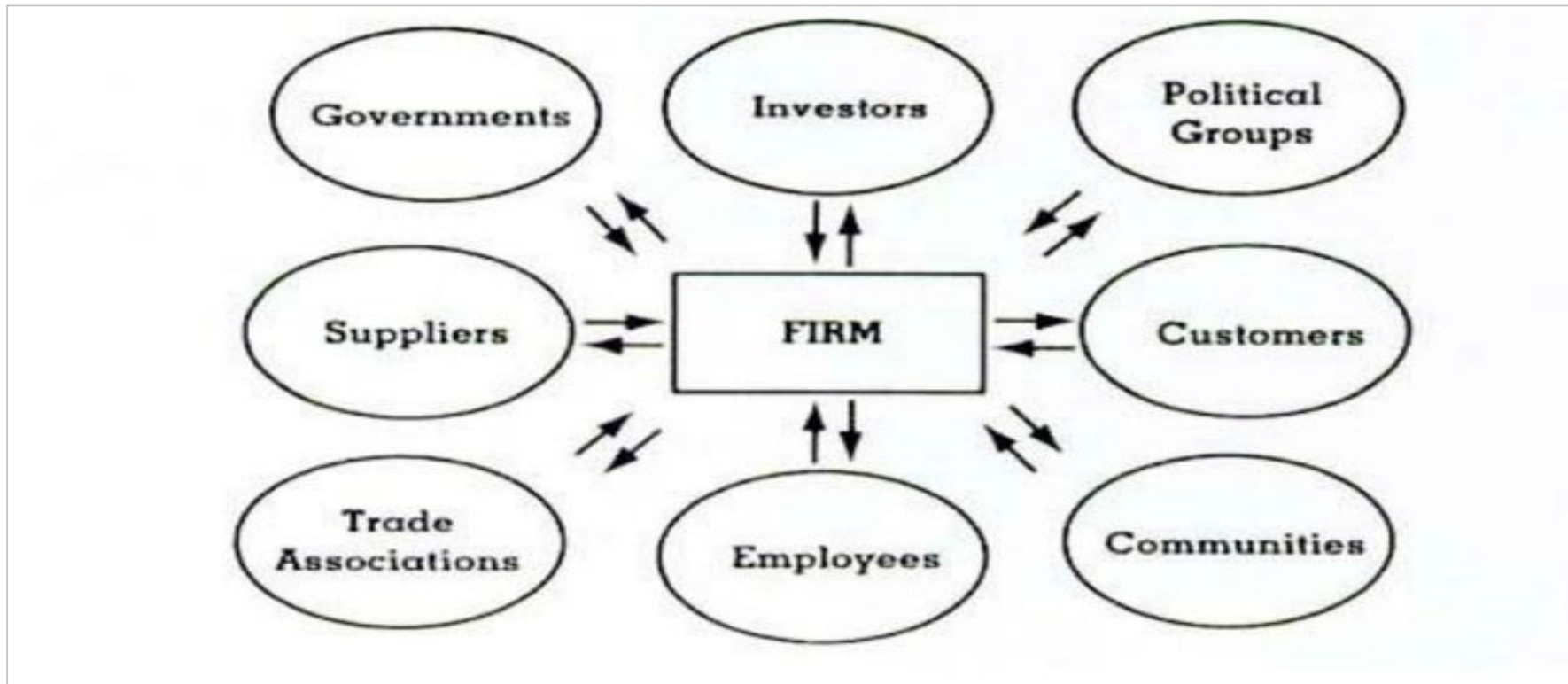
- **Owners** (e.g., investors, shareholders, agents, analysts, and ratings agencies).
- **Customers** (e.g., direct customers, indirect customers, and advocates).
- **Employees** (e.g., current employees, potential employees, suppliers' employees, retirees, representatives, and dependents).
- **Industry** (e.g., suppliers, competitors, industry associations, industry opinion leaders, and media).
- **Community** (e.g., residents near company facilities, chambers of commerce, resident associations, schools, community organizations, and special interest groups).
- **Environment** (e.g., nature, non-human species, future generations, scientists, ecologists, spiritual communities, advocates, and nongovernmental organizations, or NGOs).
- **Government** (e.g., public authorities and local policymakers, regulators, and opinion leaders).
- **Civil society organizations** (e.g., NGOs, faith-based organizations, labor unions, and general public).

Stakeholder analysis (BSR 2019)

Stakeholder	Influence	Expertise	Orientation	Vulnerability	Capacity	Trust
A	High: Stakeholder is a key shaper of opinion in this field	High: Knowledge in the issue is of value to the company	High: Proactive group that is highly engaged with business	High: The company/ project will directly impact the lives of this group	Low: The group has few resources for engagement	Low: Mutual trust is low
B	Medium	Medium	High	Medium	Medium	Low
C	Low	Low	Medium	Low	Medium	Medium
D	Low	Medium	Low	Medium	Medium	High
E	High	Medium	Low	High	High	Low

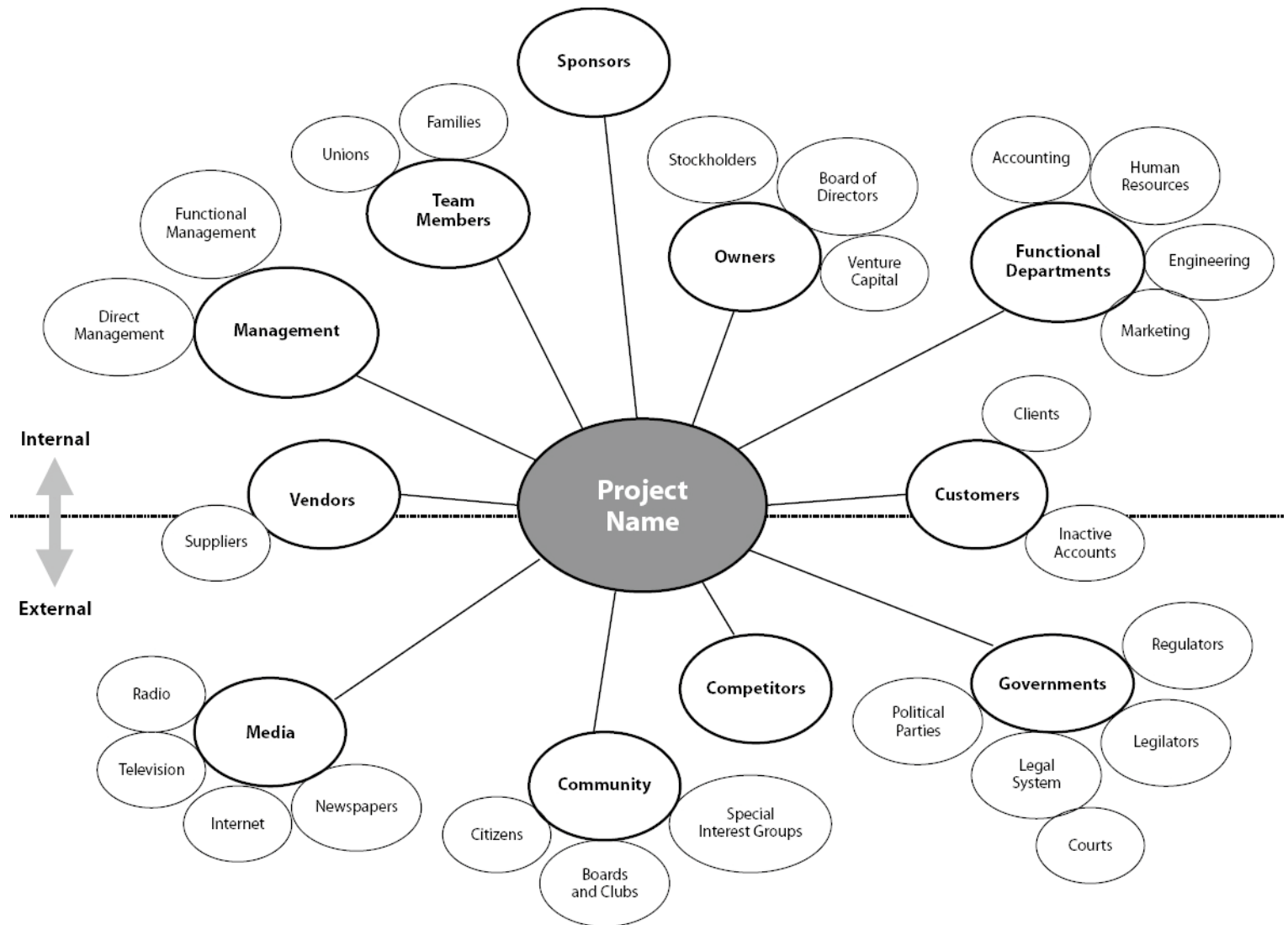
BSR. 2019. Five-Step Approach to Stakeholder Engagement. Business for Social Responsibility.

A stakeholder map (Donaldson & Preston, 1995; Freeman, 1984)

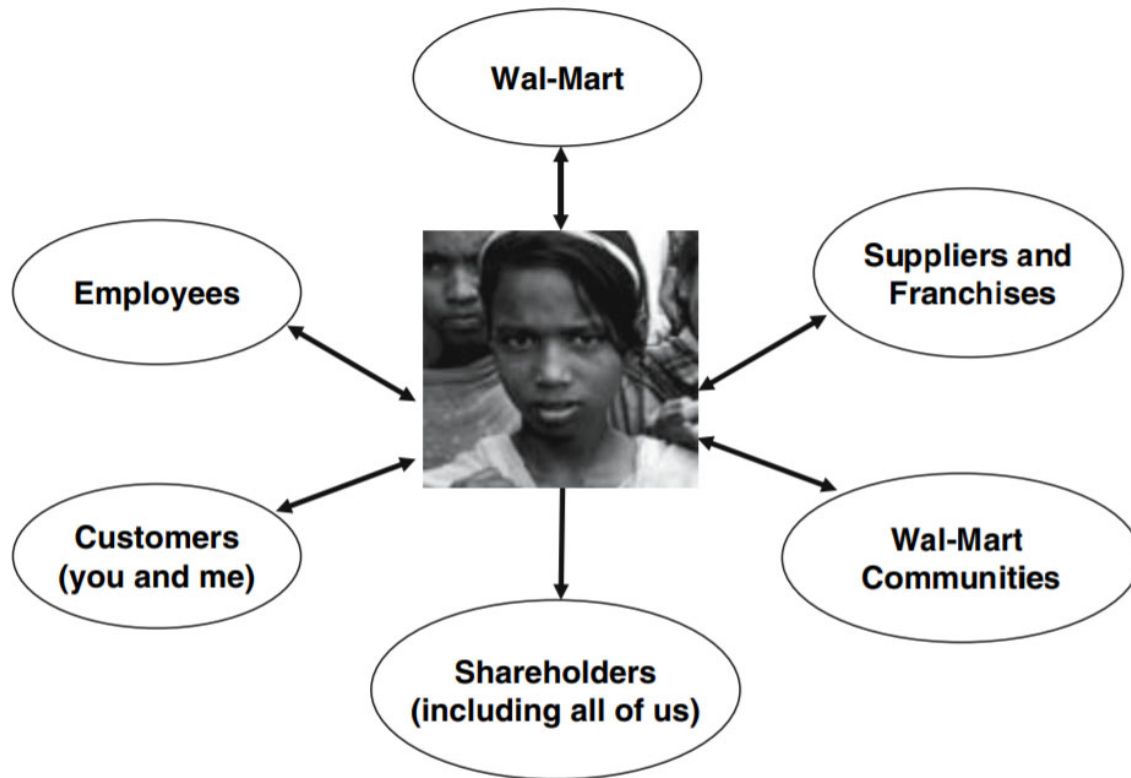


Freeman, R.E. (1984). Strategic Management: a stakeholder approach. Boston: Pitman. / Donaldson, T. & Preston, L.E. 1995. The Stakeholder Theory of the Corporation: Concepts, Evidence, and Implications. Academy of Management Review, 20(1).

An example of a stakeholder map

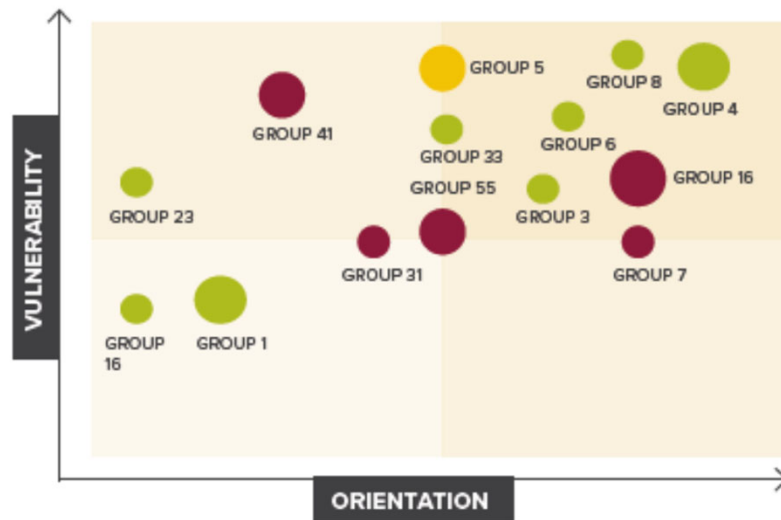


Names and faces approach (Werhane 2008; McVea & Freeman, 2005)



Werhane, P.W. 2008. Mental Models, Moral Imagination and System Thinking in the Age of Globalization. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 78, 463–474. /
McVea, J. & R. E. Freeman. 2005. A Names-and-Faces Approach to Stakeholder Management. *Journal of Management Inquiry* 14, 57–69.

Stakeholder mapping (BSR 2019)



ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE: Mapping Vulnerability and Orientation of Civil Society Group as a Step to Engagement on Human Rights Impact

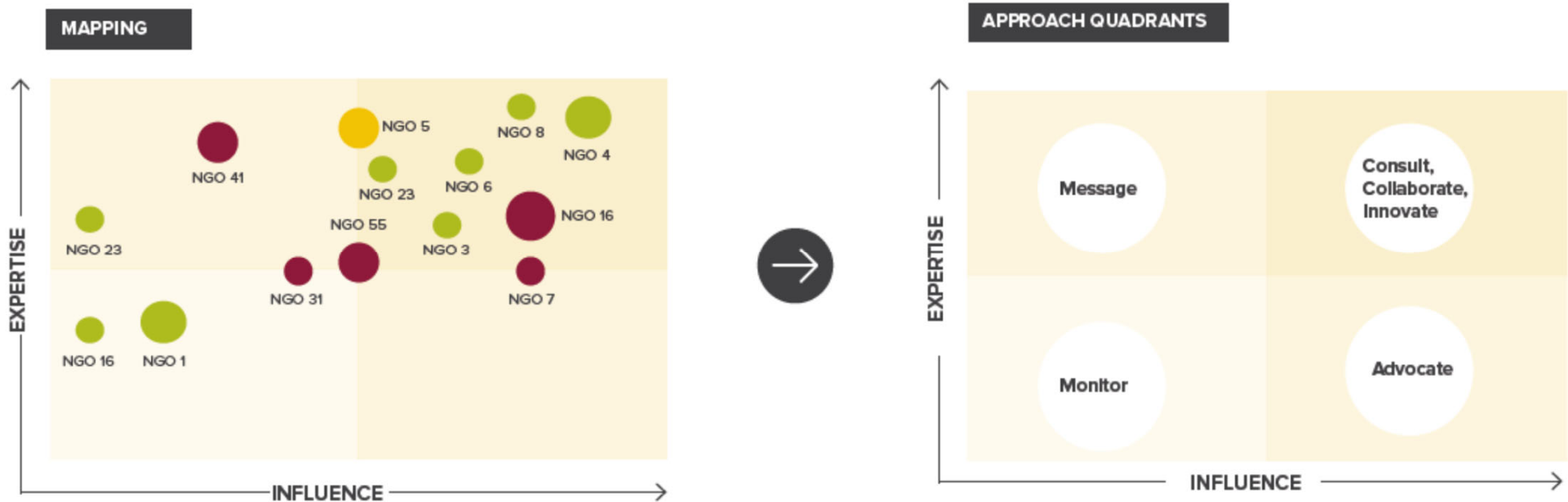
- CIVIL SOCIETY GROUP IN SOUTH AMERICA
- CIVIL SOCIETY GROUP IN ASIA
- CIVIL SOCIETY GROUP IN NORTH AMERICA
- CIVIL SOCIETY GROUP IN EUROPE

Stakeholder engagement (BSR 2019)

	ENGAGEMENT APPROACH	OVERVIEW
	MONITOR	Tracking or monitoring stakeholder positions via research or discussion with other parties.
	MESSAGE	Adapting communications scope and messaging to meet stakeholder expectations. Creating and targeting messages to specific stakeholders.
	ADVOCATE	Activities to enlist support for a specific effort or position that may have opposition or reflect an actual or perceived imbalance of power. Does not necessarily imply that the company will change its approach or direction.
	CONSULT	Soliciting explicit feedback or input on a project or plan. Implies an expectation by the stakeholders that the company will make concrete changes based on the consultation.
	COLLABORATE	Initiating or participating in two-way dialogue focused on mutual learning and solutions. Can include co-creation of new ideas and approaches.
	INNOVATE	Shared work on common objectives of the company and its stakeholders. Can include co-creation, as well as co-implementation, of new ideas.

BSR. 2019. Five-Step Approach to Stakeholder Engagement. Business for Social Responsibility.

Stakeholder engagement (BSR 2019)



Case Fairphone

Examples of strategies:

1. Focus on sustainable impact
2. Maximize market share
3. Sell off company to competitor

Question:

How would the stakeholder engagement of the firm look like depending on the strategy they choose?





4. Recap

Picture source: <https://jamesclear.com/sun-tzu-habits>



Recap

1. Changing behavior

2. Corporate responsibility and sustainability

- Drivers of corporate responsibility
- Corporate responsibility and digital economy

3. Stakeholder thinking

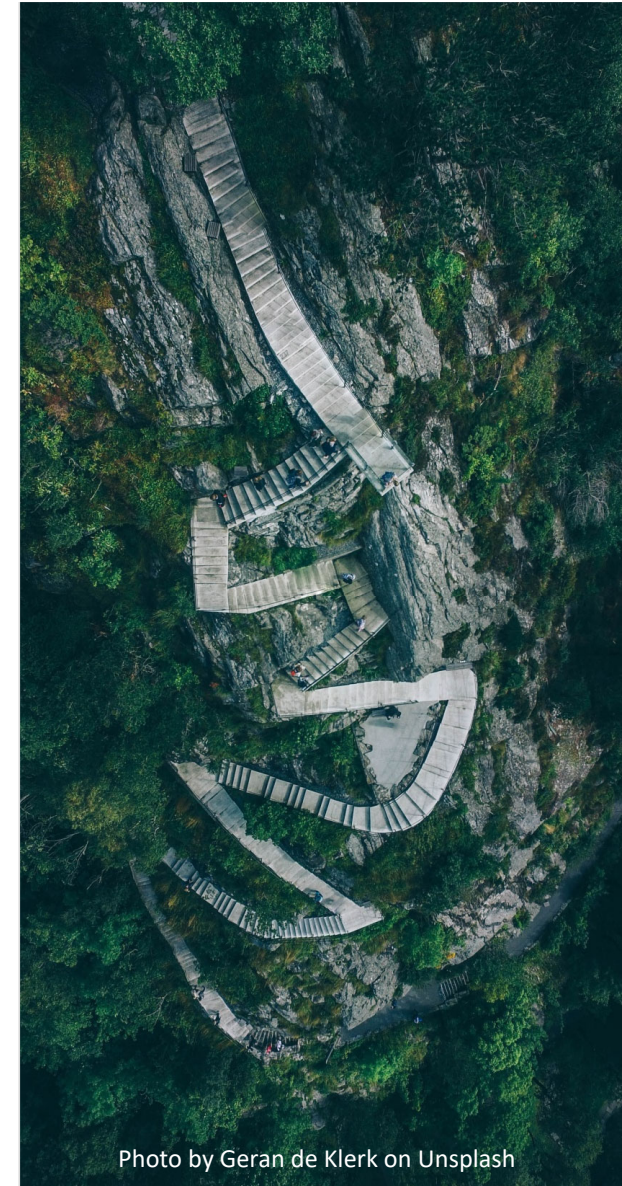


Photo by Geran de Klerk on Unsplash